December and asked him to intervene. He did so first in a surprisingly sober statement that urged a US veto. “This puts Israel in a very poor negotiating position and is extremely unfair to all Israelis,” he said. Then he went a step further and called the Egyptian president. Relations between the US and Egypt soured after the 2013 coup, but Abdel Fattah al-Sisi had high hopes for the new administration. The two men met in New York in September, on the sidelines of the General Assembly, and Sisi was the first world leader to call with congratulations after the election. He didn’t want to start the new relationship on a sour note.

So he postponed the measure, only to have four other states—Malaysia, New Zealand, Senegal and Venezuela—pick it up. They brought it to a vote the next evening. It passed by a 14–0 vote, with an abstention from the United States. “It is sad because our most important ally has abandoned a policy which has existed since 1967,” said Michael Oren. This was untrue. The measure was hardly unprecedented: its language was nearly identical to a 1979 resolution that the US also declined to veto. Since then, the settler population has grown thirty-fold, and no blue-helmeted peacekeepers have descended on Ariel and Efrat. It was purely symbolic. “The United States has been sending the message that the settlements must stop—privately and publicly—for nearly five decades,” said Samantha Power, the US ambassador at the UN. “So our vote today is fully in line with the bipartisan history of how American presidents have approached both the issue.”

Israel, needless to say, took a different view. The reaction was unprecedented in its fury. “The Obama administration carried out a shameful anti-Israel ploy at the UN,” Netanyahu said the following night in his first public comments on the matter. “The entire Middle East is going up in flames and the Obama administration and the Security Council choose to gang up on the only democracy in the Middle East.” On Christmas Day, the foreign ministry summoned the ambassador from each country that voted “yes” for an individual démarche. Dan Shapiro, the outgoing US ambassador, got a higher-level reprimand, in the form of a forty-minute meeting with Netanyahu, who also canceled meetings with Theresa May and the Ukrainian prime minister, halted Israel’s contributions to various UN bodies, and suspended economic aid to countries like Senegal and Angola that voted yes.

The worst vitriol was reserved for President Obama. Politicians and journalists called him a coward, a traitor—even Antiochus, the villain of the